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HER STORY, REWRITTEN



*Eight women of the Bible, the moment everything turned, and
what their stories are still saying to yours.*

BY MK PARRISH · \$24

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

I want to tell you something about the women in this book before you meet them.

None of them knew they were in the Bible.

They were not sitting for a portrait. They were not being holy for an audience. They were living ordinary, complicated, often unbearable lives — running out of water in a desert, burying a husband, hiding a scandal, praying so hard their lips moved without sound and someone assumed they were drunk. They were, most of them, at the lowest chapter of their own story when the moment came that turned it. And then someone wrote it down, and thousands of years later it landed in your hands.

Here is the thing I most want you to hold onto: the moment that turned their story was almost never the moment they became impressive. It was the moment they were *seen*. The moment they stopped being the person the world had written them as — the barren one, the foreigner, the used-up one, the woman with a past — and became the person God had been writing them as the whole time.

That is what this book is about. Not eight lessons in being good. Eight women whose stories got rewritten — and the strong, unsentimental hope that yours is being rewritten too, probably right now, probably in the exact chapter you would most like to skip.

You do not need to know your way around a Bible to read this. You do not need to have your faith figured out, or your life figured out, or your Sundays free. You need to be a woman who suspects, quietly, that the story she has been telling about herself might not be the whole truth. That is the only qualification. It happens to be the same one all eight of these women had.

Let me introduce you.

EVE — THE FIRST TIME SHAME LEARNED OUR NAME

We have to start at the beginning, and the beginning is not comfortable.

You know the outline even if you have never opened a Bible: a garden, a tree, a piece of fruit, a mistake that unspooled the whole world. Eve gets blamed for a lot. For most of history her name has been shorthand for *the woman who ruined it*. If you grew up anywhere near a church, you may have absorbed her as a cautionary tale before you were old enough to spell her name.

But read the story slowly and something else surfaces. The very first thing that happens after the fruit is not punishment. It is hiding. *They heard God walking in the garden, and they hid*. The oldest human instinct in the record is not sin — sin is a heartbeat before. The oldest human instinct is shame. The reflex to cover, to disappear, to make yourself smaller before you can be found out.

If you have ever gone quiet in a room because you were sure that if people really knew you they would leave — you have met Eve. You know her wilderness. It is not a place. It is a feeling: the certainty that the real you is a thing to be hidden.

Here is the line most people skip. God comes looking anyway. He walks into the garden calling a question He already knows the answer to — *Where are you?* — not to trap her, but because that is what love does when someone is hiding. It goes and finds them. It says the name into the dark.

Eve's story is the first rewrite in the whole book, and it sets the pattern for every one that follows: the story you tell about yourself begins with *hide*. The story God is telling begins with *where are you, I am coming to find you*. Those are two different books about the same woman. You get to choose which one you are living in.

You are not the mistake you are most afraid someone will discover. You are the one being looked for. Start there.

HAGAR — THE WOMAN WHO NAMED GOD IN THE DESERT

Hagar had none of the things a story usually gives its heroine. She was a servant, a foreigner, a woman used to solve someone else's problem and then discarded when the problem got complicated. When we meet her, she is pregnant, mistreated, and running — out into the desert with no plan, because staying had become worse than the wilderness.

And in the desert, at a spring of water, an angel finds her. Not a general. Not a king. A pregnant runaway slave that the whole society had agreed did not matter.

What she does next is one of the most astonishing things in the entire Bible, and almost nobody knows it: *she gives God a name.* She is the only person in all of Scripture to do so. She calls Him *El Roi* — *the God who sees me.* And then she says the line I think about constantly: *I have now seen the One who sees me.*

Sit with what that means. The person at the very bottom of her world's ranking, the one nobody was looking at, discovers that she has been seen the entire time. Not managed. Not tolerated. *Seen* — the way you long to be seen, all the way down, and wanted anyway.

If you have ever been the one doing the invisible work — holding a family together, carrying a job nobody credits you for, loving people who look straight through you — Hagar's desert is your desert. And her God is a God who has a particular habit of showing up exactly there, in the place you went to fall apart, and calling you by your real name.

The world had written Hagar as *nobody's story.* God met her in the desert and rewrote the first line: *seen.* Everything after that is just detail.

HANNAH — THE PRAYER THEY MISTOOK FOR DRUNKENNESS

Hannah wanted a child and did not have one, and in her world that was not a private sorrow — it was a public verdict. Year after year she went up to the temple carrying an ache she could not fix, and year after year she came home still empty, still whispered about.

One day the ache broke open. She went to the temple and prayed so hard, so entirely, that her lips moved and no sound came out. The priest watched her from across the room and assumed she was drunk. Even in her holiest moment, she was misread by the man whose job was to know better.

I love Hannah for what she does with that. She does not perform. She does not clean herself up. She says, plainly: *I am a woman who is deeply troubled. I have been pouring out my soul.* She refuses to let anyone shrink her grief into something more presentable. She brings the whole unedited thing to God — not the polished prayer, the real one, the one with tears in it.

Here is what her story teaches about rewriting yours: you do not have to arrive at God impressive, or grateful-yet, or over it. You are allowed to come exactly as troubled as you actually are. The rewrite does not start when you finally feel strong. It starts when you stop editing yourself down for God's comfort and hand Him the true version.

Hannah's prayer was answered, and she got her son. But the turn in her story happens *before* the answer — in the moment she decided to be fully honest with God about how much it hurt. That is the part you can copy tonight, whether or not you ever get the thing you are aching for. Bring the unedited version. He can read your handwriting.

RUTH — THE WOMAN WHO CHOSE HER OWN LOYALTY

Ruth's story begins in a graveyard's worth of loss. Her husband is dead. Her sister-in-law's husband is dead. Her mother-in-law, Naomi, has lost everything and is heading back to her homeland bitter and broke, telling the younger women to go home to their own mothers and start over. It is the sensible advice. It is the exit anyone would take.

Ruth does not take it. She says the words that have been read at weddings for three thousand years, except she is not saying them to a lover — she is saying them to a heartbroken older woman with nothing left to offer her:

Where you go I will go. Your people will be my people. Your God, my God.

Understand how strange this is. Ruth is choosing loyalty when loyalty has no payoff. She is a foreigner attaching herself to a woman who can give her no future, in a country that has no reason to welcome her. Every incentive says walk away. She writes a different line.

And that line — that stubborn, unrewarded, chosen loyalty — becomes the hinge the whole rest of the Bible turns on. Ruth the outsider, the woman from the wrong nation, ends up in the family tree of kings. Of the Messiah. The foreigner nobody would have bet on becomes the great-grandmother of David.

Ruth's story is proof that the chapter where you have the least to gain is often the one that decides everything. She did not know she was writing history. She just refused to abandon someone when it would have been easier to. Sometimes the most important line in your story is the loyal one you write when no one is clapping.

Your background does not disqualify you from the story God is telling. Ask Ruth. Ask the outsider they put at the root of the family tree.

ESTHER — FOR SUCH A TIME AS THIS

Esther had a secret and a crown, and both were about to cost her everything.

She was a Jewish orphan who became a queen without anyone at the palace knowing what she was. When a genocide against her people got signed into law, she had a choice that is more modern than it sounds: keep her head down and stay safe in the palace, or speak up and risk her life on behalf of people who could not save themselves.

Her cousin sends her the sentence that has echoed for millennia: *Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?* In other words — what if the whole strange, unlikely road that got you here was not an accident? What if the position you are tempted to protect is actually the position you were placed in to use?

Esther's answer is not fearless. That is what makes it usable. She is terrified. She fasts for three days first. And then she says the bravest sentence a scared person can say: *If I perish, I perish.* Not *I am sure it will work out.* Not *I feel called and confident.* Just — *I am going to do the right thing and I am going to let go of controlling how it ends.*

If you are sitting in a life that does not feel like it was designed for anything — a job, a city, a season you did not choose — Esther's story asks a question worth staying up over. What if you are not stuck here. What if you are *positioned* here. What if the thing you would have to risk to matter is exactly the thing you have been clutching.

You do not have to feel brave to be brave. You just have to move while you are afraid. Esther did, and a whole people lived because she rewrote her own instinct to stay safe.

THE WOMAN AT THE WELL — FIVE CHAPTERS SHE WANTED TO SKIP

She came to the well at noon, which tells you everything before she says a word. Everyone else drew water in the cool of the morning, together, talking. She came at the hottest, emptiest hour — alone, on purpose, to avoid the other women and the way they looked at her. She had had five husbands and was living with a man who was not one. In her town, she was the story people told to warn their daughters.

And a man is sitting at the well. A Jewish man, who by every rule of the day should not speak to her — wrong gender, wrong nation, wrong reputation. He asks her for a drink. And then he does the thing she came to the well at noon specifically to avoid: he names her whole history out loud. *You have had five husbands, and the man you have now is not your husband.*

Here is the miracle, and it is not the one you would expect. She does not flinch and run. Because of *how* He says it. There is no sneer in it. He names the exact thing she is most ashamed of, the five chapters she would give anything to skip, and there is not one drop of contempt. He sees the whole record and stays in the conversation. He offers her, of all people, *living water* — a thing she will never be thirsty again for.

She drops her water jar — the whole reason she came — and runs back into the town she had been hiding from, and says: *Come see a man who told me everything I ever did.* The thing she was hiding becomes the thing she can't stop talking about. Her worst chapters become her testimony. She becomes the first evangelist in the Gospel of John, and she does it with a resume the whole town used against her.

Your past is not the disqualification you think it is. In God's editing, the chapters you are most ashamed of are often the ones He uses to reach people no polished testimony ever could. The woman at the well did not get a clean slate. She got something better — a rewritten meaning for the slate she already had.

MARY MAGDALENE — THE FIRST TO CARRY THE NEWS

For most of history, Mary Magdalene has been slandered by a rumor the Bible never actually tells — people melted her together with other women and turned her into a fallen woman, a reputation she never earned in the text. What the Bible does say is stranger and better: she was a woman Jesus had freed from real torment, and she followed Him all the way to the end, when almost everyone else had run.

She was there at the cross when it was dangerous to be there. She was there at the tomb before the sun came up, carrying spices to tend a dead body, because grief will get you out of bed in the dark to do useless, loving things. And the tomb was open, and empty, and she fell apart — assumed someone had stolen the body, because that is a more believable story than the one about to happen to her.

Then a voice says one word. Her name. *Mary.* And the whole world reorganizes itself around the sound of it.

Of all the people the resurrected Christ could have appeared to first — kings, priests, the men who would go on to run the whole movement — He appears first to her. A grieving woman that history would spend centuries trying to reduce. And He gives her the first assignment of the new world:

Go and tell them. She becomes the apostle to the apostles. The first human being to carry the most important sentence ever spoken: *He is alive.*

She was written off, and then she was written *in* — placed at the center of the single most important morning in the Christian story. If you have been reduced by other people's rumors, if the version of you that circulates is not the true one, hold on to this: the record can be corrected.

The One whose opinion actually decides things looked at the woman everyone underestimated and handed her the news the whole future depended on.

He says your name the same way. Not the label. The name.

MARTHA — LEARNING WHAT THE BETTER THING ACTUALLY IS

We end with a quieter woman, because not every rewrite is a lightning bolt. Some are a slow, gentle correction to the way you have been carrying your life.

Martha opened her home to Jesus and then did what capable women do — she started *serving*. Cooking, arranging, managing, making it all work, while her sister Mary just sat at Jesus's feet and listened. And Martha did the thing every tired, competent woman has done: she looked at the person who was *resting* and got resentful, and she asked Jesus to make her sister get up and help.

His answer is famous and easy to hear as a scolding, but it isn't one.

Martha, Martha — He says her name twice, softly, the way you say it to someone you love who is running themselves ragged — *you are worried and upset about many things, but few things are needed. Mary has chosen what is better.*

He is not saying the work does not matter. He is saying *she* matters more than her usefulness, and she has forgotten it. Martha had quietly come to believe that her worth was in what she produced, that love had to be earned by keeping the whole house running. And Jesus gently pulls the thread out of her hands and says: sit down. Be here. You are allowed to be a person, not just an engine.

If you have built a whole identity out of being the reliable one, the one who handles it, the one who never sits down — Martha is your rewrite. The story you have been telling says *I am valued because I am useful.* The story Jesus tells says *you are valued, full stop, and the serving was never the price of that.*

There is a Martha in most of us. She does not need to be scolded. She needs to be told her name twice, softly, and given permission to put the tray down.

YOUR TURN

You have met eight women now. Look at what they had in common, because it is the whole point.

Not one of them earned the turn in her story by becoming impressive. Eve was hiding. Hagar was running. Hannah was falling apart. Ruth had nothing. Esther was terrified. The woman at the well had a past. Mary Magdalene was grieving. Martha was exhausted. Every single rewrite began at the bottom of the page, in the chapter each of them would have paid to skip. And every single one turned on the same thing: they were *seen* — fully, without contempt — and the seeing changed what the story was about.

That is the offer still on the table. It has your name on it.

The story you have been telling about yourself — the one where you are the barren one, the foreigner, the used-up one, the invisible one, the one with the past, the one who is only as good as what she produces — is not the true story. It is a draft. It is the version the world scribbled in the margins and you mistook for the manuscript. There is another book being written about you, and it has been going the whole time, quietly, underneath, by an Author who has never once looked at you with contempt and who knows your name well enough to say it twice.

You do not rewrite your story by trying harder to be good. You rewrite it by letting yourself be seen — by bringing the unedited version, the one with the tears in it, and letting the One who sees you tell you what it actually means. That is where every one of these eight women turned. That is where you turn too.

So here is your assignment, and it is the same one the woman at the well got. Go and tell them. Not a cleaned-up story — the true one. The one where you were at the bottom of the page and got found there. Somebody

in your life is at the well at noon right now, hiding from the morning crowd, certain her chapters disqualify her. You are the proof they don't.

Her story got rewritten. So did hers, and hers, and all six of the others.

Yours is next. It might already be underway.

This is the first book in the **Her Story, Rewritten** *line from MK Parrish —*
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rest of the series, the journals, and the free reader's guide, come rewrite your
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